DEPARTMENT OF curriculum +instruction

second languages education

Timing

1. The prelim exams are taken during the regular academic year; you can write in the summer, but faculty do not read exams. The prelim written exam is taken towards the end of coursework, typically in the 3rd year for a full - time student.
2. Before taking prelims, you are required to take the SLC year-long research seminar (CI 8161 + CI 8162, offered every other year). If circumstances warrant, it may be possible for you to take prelims concurrently with the seminar.
3. The time frame to complete your written exam varies and is negotiated with your committee member, but is ideally 4-6 weeks.
4. Once you submit the written exam to the committee member who assigned the question, the committee member reads it and informs you and your adviser of the outcome (in writing,usually via email) within 2-3 weeks. Your advisor will inform you of your results: 'pass', if 'revisions are required', or 'fail'. Readers usually give general feedback in a response paragraph. The length of time allowed for the re-write is stipulated by the committee member, typically within one month. If you fail two or more exams on the second chance, you will be counseled out of the program.
5. Once you pass all of the written exams, you should schedule a two-hour meeting for the oral exam by contacting all committee members and arranging for a room (through graduate studies). We encourage to schedule the orals as soon as possible after you pass your written exams.

Written Exam

For SLC, the prelim process is both forward-oriented and cumulative. The prelims are an opportunity to move towards the dissertation by integrating past work and synthesizing additional work (rather than simply summarizing topics covered in coursework). The purpose of the exam is an opportunity for you to demonstrate sufficient knowledge of the scholarly work related to the dissertation topic (as well as broader SLC field), analytical thinking, and academic writing skills, such that completing the dissertation is possible. Students are expected to draw from high quality research literature.

The written exam is take-home. The topics and length are negotiated with the committee members for whom you are writing. You are responsible for asking faculty members to serve on your committee. Your advisor supervises the process to ensure that questions are complementary and not redundant. One question must be about research methodology. You are encouraged as ask clarifying questions if you do not understand the premise of exam.

Oral Exam

Assessing knowledge of the field and the preparation/readiness needed for successful completion of dissertation.

Technically the preliminary oral exam can include questions about the written exams and past coursework, but typically the focus is on assessing knowledge for the dissertation (using the written exams as the springboard for the discussion). If the oral exam progresses well, the last 30 minutes or so typically focus on specific plans for the dissertation.